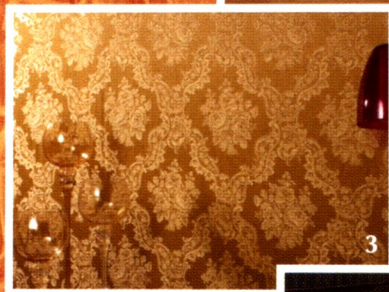


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BOX POPULI

...come to be the last resort of politicians south of the Vindhyas as parties launch channels to spread their ideologies as well as rake in some moolah

■ By M.G. Radhakrishnan

For nearly four decades, politics and cinema have had a cosy marriage in the southern states, with film stars and scriptwriters heading governments in Andhra Pradesh and Tamil Nadu. But if recent trends are any indication, south Indian politics is all set to divorce its first spouse—cinema, and enter into a wedlock with the relatively younger, but more influential mistress, television. Such is the zeal with which not just the political parties in south India, but also warring factions within are jumping on to the TV channel bandwagon.

In Tamil Nadu, the ruling DMK recently launched Kalaigamar TV to fight the mammoth Sun TV Network owned by the family of former Union telecommunications minister Dayanidhi Maran, who was ousted

from the party. AIADMK's J. Jayalalithaa owns the Jaya TV and the Pattali Makkal Katchi (PMK), a constituent of UPA, owns Makkal TV. In Kerala, the Congress launched Jai Hind TV to take on the CPI(M)-backed Kairali TV. The state's first 24-hour news channel, Indiavision, is headed by M.K. Muneer, a Muslim League leader and a former minister. In Karnataka, H.D. Kumaraswamy may

CABLE VISION: DMK's Karunanidhi launched Kalaigamar to take on Sun



have lost his job as chief minister, but he won't be sitting idle since his wife Anita, who heads Amogh Broadband services which is a prominent cable operator company, has just launched the Kannada Kasturi channel. In Andhra Pradesh, former chief minister Chandrababu Naidu doesn't need to float a channel since the state's largest television network has voluntarily taken on the role of TDP's main propagandist while Chief Minister Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy is buoyed by remarks made by both Sonia Gandhi and Information and Broadcasting Minister Priya Ranjan Dasmuni that the Congress will launch television channels in all languages. In Tamil Nadu, where the Congress has as many factions as it has leaders, two party bigwigs have announced television channels—Vasanth TV and Mega TV—with the blessings of the high command, as